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The Cursed Caravan

An Adventure for Fate's Edge Acasia

Adventure Overview

Title: The Cursed Caravan
Region: Acasia Broken Marches
Theme: Supernatural horror, cursed objects, moral ambiguity
Level: Seasoned (Tier II)
Length: 34 Sessions

1 Premise

A merchant caravan has been cursed while crossing the Pale Causeway, causing supplies to rot, animals to die, and strange omens to appear. The players must escort the caravan to safety while dealing with the curse's escalating effects. However, they soon discover that the curse is tied to a larger conspiracy involving a powerful entity that feeds on suffering and despair, and that the caravan's troubles may be just the beginning of something far worse.

2 Hook

The adventure begins when the players encounter one of the following scenarios (Investigation + Notice vs DV 3 to determine truth):

tem **Desperate Merchant:** They find the caravan stalled on the road, with Merchant Aldric Thorne desperately seeking help for his dying animals and rotting supplies. He offers them a substantial reward to help get the caravan to the nearest settlement. (Social encounter, Presence + Sway vs DV 3) tem **False Accusation:** A Margravine's bounty poster shows the players' faces with the accusation that they're responsible for the curse, forcing them to investigate to clear their names. (Investigation + Subterfuge vs DV 4) tem **Witch's Warning:** HedgeWitch Mira Blackwood approaches them in a tavern, warning that something dark is moving along the trade routes and that they may be the only ones who can stop it. (Social encounter, Presence + Insight vs DV 3)

3 Key Factions

3.1 The Merchant's Caravan

The Merchant's Caravan tem[Leader:] Merchant Aldric Thorne tem[Description:] Desperate traders trying to save their livelihood tem[Key Members:] Serah Thorne, Garrick the Guard, Mason the

Cook tem[Strengths:] Local trade knowledge, practical survival skills tem[Weaknesses:] Limited supernatural understanding, dwindling resources tem[Methods:] Pragmatic problemsolving, appeals to authority tem[Position:] Desperate (cursed caravan), may improve with player help tem[DV for Assistance:] 2 (desperate need), 3 (normal), 4+ (suspicious)

3.2 The Pale Shepherd

The Pale Shepherd tem[Description:] Mysterious figure associated with transitions and endings tem[Role:] Guide for the lost, guardian of boundaries tem[Strengths:] Supernatural knowledge, ability to appear at crucial moments tem[Weaknesses:] Enigmatic motives, limited direct intervention tem[Methods:] Guidance through omens, appearing at crossroads tem[Position:] Dominant in liminal spaces, Controlled elsewhere tem[DV for Guidance:] 4 (proper approach), 5 (neutral), 6+ (improper)

3.3 The Hungering Dark

The Hungering Dark tem[Type:] Ancient Outsider (Cap 4) tem[Tags:] [FEED], [DARK], [CURSE], [FEAR] tem[Description:] Entity that feeds on suffering, despair, and life force tem[Strengths:] Growing power through feeding, supernatural manipulation tem[Weaknesses:] Vulnerable to proper containment rituals, lightbased effects tem[Methods:] Spreading curse, manipulating emotions, possessing weakwilled tem[Position:] Controlled (growing), Desperate (when threatened)

4 Key NPCs

4.1 Merchant Aldric Thorne

Merchant Aldric Thorne tem[Role:] Caravan leader, desperate trader tem[Age:] 45 tem[Skills:] Command 3, Survival 3, Sway 2 tem[Knowledge:] Trade routes, caravan management, local markets tem[Motivation:] Save livelihood and family reputation tem[Complication:] Skeptical of supernatural but desperate enough to try anything tem[Position:] Desperate (cursed caravan), Controlled with player help tem[DV for Persuasion:] 3 (mutual benefit), 4 (neutral), 5+ (suspicious)

4.2 HedgeWitch Mira Blackwood

HedgeWitch Mira Blackwood tem[Role:] Local supernatural practitioner tem[Age:] 68 tem[Skills:] Arcana 4, Lore 3, Insight 3 tem[Knowledge:] Local folklore, curse origins, protective rituals tem[Motivation:] Protect local community from supernatural threats tem[Complication:] Knows more than she reveals, has personal stake tem[Position:] Dominant (local knowledge), Controlled under direct threat tem[DV for Information:] 4 (proper respect), 5 (neutral), 6+ (hostile)

4.3 Margravine Xara Rothari

Margravine Xara Rothari tem[Role:] Regional ruler of Broken Marches tem[Age:] 52 tem[Skills:] Command 4, Insight 3, Sway 3 tem[Knowledge:] Regional politics, law enforcement, trade regulation tem[Motivation:] Maintain order and authority tem[Complication:] Balancing justice with practical concerns tem[Position:] Dominant (authority), Controlled under political pressure tem[DV for Negotiation:] 4 (legitimate request), 5 (neutral), 6+ (opposition)

4.4 The Cursed Child

The Cursed Child tem[Type:] Legendary Outsider (Cap 5) tem[Tags:] [OMEN], [BARGAIN], [END], [FEAR] tem[Description:] Folkloric figure appearing at curse climax tem[Abilities:]

tem Appear at moments of greatest despair tem Offer terrible bargains tem End conflicts through supernatural means tem Induce overwhelming fear

tem[Weaknesses:] Bound by folklore rules, vulnerable to proper ritual tem[Tactics:] Prefer bargains to direct confrontation tem[Position:] Dominant at curse climax tem[DV for Bargaining:] 6 (terrible bargain), 5 (difficult), 4 (possible)

5 Key Locations

5.1 The Pale Causeway

The Pale Causeway tem[Description:] Last high road surviving spring thaws, crucial trade route tem[Features:] Warnings, protective charms, shifting terrain tem[Curse Effects:]

tem Navigation becomes difficult (Survival vs DV 4) tem Protective charms failing (Arcana vs DV 5 to maintain) tem Road seems to shift and change (Notice vs DV 3)

tem[Challenges:]

tem Guiding caravan safely (Leadership challenge, DV 4) tem Dealing with supernatural interference (Combat/Skill, DV 5) tem Maintaining morale (Command vs DV 4)

tem[Position:] Controlled (normal), Desperate (strong curse influence)

5.2 Blackwood Hollow

Blackwood Hollow tem[Description:] Charcoal burner's clearing with hedgewitch's dwelling tem[Features:] Protective charms, local folklore knowledge, supernatural sanctuary tem[Protection:] Strong wards resist curse influence tem[Challenges:]

tem Gaining hedgewitch's trust (Social challenge, DV 4) tem Learning curse origins (Lore + Arcana vs DV 5) tem Accessing supernatural knowledge (Extended challenge, DV 6)

tem[Position:] Dominant (protected area), may weaken if curse grows

5.3 The Margravine's Court

The Margravine's Court tem[Description:] Fortresslike seat of regional authority tem[Features:] Iron law, harsh justice, bureaucratic complexity tem[Political Climate:] Disrupted by curse, increasing tension tem[Challenges:]

tem Navigating legal proceedings (Sway + Command vs DV 5) tem Presenting evidence of supernatural threat (Lore vs DV 4) tem Dealing with harsh justice system (Social challenge, DV 5)

tem[Security:] Heavily guarded, formal protocols required

5.4 The Salt Road Ford

The Salt Road Ford tem[Description:] Crucial river crossing point tem[Features:] Unnaturally cold water, treacherous crossing, bonefilled banks tem[Curse Effects:]

tem Water becomes dangerous (Athletics vs DV 4) tem Crossing becomes treacherous (Survival vs DV 5) tem Supernatural presence increases fear (Spirit vs DV 4)

tem[Challenges:]

tem Safely crossing with caravan (Extended challenge, DV 5) tem Dealing with supernatural interference (Combat/Skill, DV 4) tem Maintaining animal control (Command vs DV 3)

tem[Position:] Desperate (cursed ford), may improve with proper precautions

5.5 The Cursed Crossroads

The Cursed Crossroads tem[Description:] Meeting point of multiple roads with wrongtime stone tem[Features:] Strong curse influence, place of choice and consequence tem[Significance:] Hungering Dark's strongest influence area tem[Challenges:]

tem Resisting supernatural influence (Spirit vs DV 6) tem Making crucial decisions under pressure (Wits + Insight vs DV 5) tem Confronting entity directly (Varies by approach)

tem[Position:] Desperate (entity's domain)

6 Plot Structure

6.1 Session 1: The Cursed Caravan

Opening Scene: Players encounter one of the hook scenarios. Establish the immediate supernatural threat and desperate situation.

Key Objectives:

tem Experience immediate effects of the curse firsthand tem Meet key caravan members and understand their motivations tem Begin suspecting supernatural involvement tem Make initial decisions about approach and commitment

Sample Encounters:

tem **Dying Animals:** Witness caravan horses succumbing to curse. (Notice + Medicine vs DV 4, Desperate/Limited) tem **Rotting Supplies:** Deal with spoiled cargo threatening caravan's viability. (Survival + Craft vs DV 3, Controlled/Standard) tem **Supernatural Omen:** Experience first clear supernatural manifestation. (Spirit + Notice vs DV 4, Desperate/Standard)

Session End: Players committed to helping caravan. Advance Curse Escalation Timer +2, Caravan Supplies 1.

6.2 Session 2: Into the Blackwood

Opening Scene: Players seek help from HedgeWitch Mira. Supernatural elements become clearer.

Key Objectives:

tem Learn about local folklore and supernatural protections tem Discover curse's connection to sealed chest tem Face growing influence of Hungering Dark tem Make moral choices about dealing with curse

Sample Encounters:

tem **HedgeWitch Consultation:** Gain supernatural knowledge and protection advice. (Presence + Lore vs DV 4, Controlled/Standard) tem **Chest Investigation:** Examine mysterious sealed cargo item. (Investigation + Arcana vs DV 5, Desperate/Standard) tem **Protective Ritual:** Perform local charm to resist curse effects. (Craft + Arcana vs DV 4, Controlled/Great)

Session End: Players understand curse's supernatural nature. Advance Hungering Dark's Strength +1, gain Folk Protection Tokens.

6.3 Session 3: The Margravine's Justice

Opening Scene: Political/legal complications arise as curse affects wider community.

Key Objectives:

tem Navigate Margravine's court and harsh justice system tem Deal with curse's effects on local community tem Confront entity behind curse directly tem Make crucial decisions about curse's ultimate fate

Sample Encounters:

tem **Court Proceedings:** Present supernatural evidence to skeptical authorities. (Command + Lore vs DV 5, Controlled/Great) tem **Community Crisis:** Deal with curse spreading to local settlement. (Leadership challenge, DV 5) tem **Direct Confrontation:** Face Hungering Dark's influence at cursed crossroads. (Extended combat/ritual, DV 6)

Session End: Major confrontation with entity. Advance all timers +1, determine path to resolution.

6.4 Session 4: The Pale Child

Opening Scene: Curse reaches climax as Cursed Child appears.

Key Objectives:

tem Face ultimate consequences of previous choices tem Deal with Cursed Child's terrible bargain tem Resolve immediate threat to caravan tem Determine longterm effects of actions

Sample Encounters:

tem **Terrible Bargain:** Negotiate with Cursed Child for resolution. (Sway + Spirit vs DV 6, Desperate/Great) tem **Final Ritual:** Perform complex containment or destruction ritual. (Extended Arcana/Craft challenge, DV 6) tem **Moral Choice:** Choose between different resolution paths with consequences. (Command + Insight vs DV 5)

Session End: Resolution of curse crisis. Final timer states determine ending.

7 Key Mechanics**7.1 Curse Escalation Timer [8]**

tem[Advance +1:] Animals die or supplies rot tem[Advance +1:] NPCs become possessed or influenced tem[Advance +2:] Players fail to properly contain the curse tem[Advance +1:] Hungering Dark successfully feeds tem[Advance +2:] Caravan members suffer serious harm tem[Advance +1:] Supernatural manifestations increase in frequency tem[When Full:] Curse reaches maximum power, entity may fully manifest

7.2 Caravan Supplies [6]

tem[Deplete 1:] Food and water spoil due to curse tem[Deplete 1:] Equipment breaks or becomes unusable tem[Deplete 1:] Animals die or become unable to work tem[Deplete 1:] Players make poor resource management decisions tem[When Empty:] Caravan cannot continue without external aid tem[Refill +1:] Successful procurement or player intervention (max 6)

7.3 Hungering Dark's Strength [6]

tem[Increase +1:] NPCs experience fear, despair, or physical suffering tem[Increase +1:] Curse's effects become more severe tem[Increase +2:] Players use violent solutions creating more suffering tem[Increase +1:] Proper supernatural protections not maintained tem[Decrease 1:] Successful containment rituals performed tem[Decrease 2:] Entity directly confronted and weakened tem[When Full:] Entity reaches peak power, may attempt to escape bounds

7.4 Folk Protection Tokens

tem[ButterLeft Charm:] Place butter in niches to keep curse at bay (1 use, +1 Position vs curse effects) tem[Red Thread Binding:] Tie red thread around wrists to maintain connection to living world (+1 die to resist possession, 1 scene) tem[SaltWarding:] Draw salt circles to contain supernatural entities (lasts until broken, DV 3 to maintain) tem[HedgeWitch's Blessing:] Gain +1 die to supernatural knowledge rolls (1 scene) tem[Crossroads Token:] Gain +1 Boon when making crucial decisions at crossroads (1 use) tem[Bone Powder:] Sprinkle to reveal supernatural tracks or influences (1 use, Investigation + Notice vs DV 4)

8 Possible Resolutions

8.1 Proper Containment

Proper Containment tem[Requirements:]

tem Perform correct rituals to bind curse (Craft + Arcana vs DV 6) tem Return object to resting place with ceremony (Extended challenge, DV 5) tem Gain blessing of local supernatural forces (Presence + Lore vs DV 4)

tem[Procedure:] Complex ritual requiring multiple steps and cooperation tem[Costs:] Significant time investment, 1 segment Corruption for each participant tem[Outcome:] Curse contained, grateful merchant, potential supernatural allies

8.2 Sacrificial Bargain

Sacrificial Bargain tem[Nature:] Terrible bargain with Hungering Dark or Cursed Child tem[Options:]

tem Offer willing sacrifice to sate entity (Social/Command challenge, DV 5) tem Trade away something of great personal value (Player choice) tem Accept geas with future consequences (Mark ongoing Complication)

tem[Procedure:] Negotiation with supernatural entity under pressure tem[Costs:] Moral compromise, ongoing supernatural debt, personal sacrifice tem[Outcome:] Immediate safety but longterm consequences, moral complexity

8.3 Destruction Solution

Destruction Solution tem[Approach:] Destroy cursed object and feeding entity tem[Requirements:]
 tem Locate proper tools/rituals for destruction (Investigation vs DV 5) tem Accept risks of dangerous undertaking (Extended challenge, DV 6) tem Deal with backlash from destroying powerful force (Combat/Skill, DV 5)

tem[Procedure:] Dangerous ritual requiring specific conditions and timing tem[Costs:] Risk of harm to participants, potential for new supernatural threats tem[Outcome:] Complete resolution but possible complications, recognition as powerful agents

8.4 Escape and Abandonment

Escape and Abandonment tem[Choice:] Save selves and abandon caravan to fate tem[Requirements:]
 tem Flee cursed area successfully (Stealth + Survival vs DV 5) tem Accept moral cost of abandonment (Player decision) tem Face longterm effects of choice (Mark ongoing Complication)

tem[Procedure:] Rapid withdrawal from situation tem[Costs:] Guilt and reputation damage, potential future encounters, loss of rewards tem[Outcome:] Personal survival but moral consequences, unresolved supernatural threat

9 Rewards and Consequences

9.1 Immediate Rewards

tem Tollexemption plaque for one bridge: Free passage on named bridge tem Monastery letter for bedandbread on a named road: +1 Position for travel on that road tem Wineright on an abandoned terrace: Access to valuable agricultural resource tem Condotta contract for one battle: Temporary military employment tem Titheremission writ for a village: Economic benefit for chosen community tem Borderstone adjustment: Modify regional boundaries for strategic advantage tem Passkey charm recognized by Pale Causeway watchmen: +1 die to interactions with authorities

9.2 Longterm Consequences

tem **Proper Containment:** Reputation as capable supernatural problemsolvers, grateful local contacts, potential for future folk horror adventures tem **Sacrificial Bargain:** Ongoing supernatural connection, moral complexity affecting future decisions, powerful but dangerous allies tem **Destruction Solution:** Recognition as powerful agents, possible new supernatural enemies, access to destroyed entity's former domain tem **Escape and Abandonment:** Damaged reputation in Broken Marches, guilt affecting character development, unresolved threat may return tem **Mixed Outcomes:** Complex relationships with all factions, ongoing plot hooks, moderate standing in region

large10 GM Notes

10.1 Atmosphere and Tone

Emphasize the bleak, desperate atmosphere of Acasia:

- tem Use descriptions of withered crops, gray skies, and desperate people
- tem Make supernatural elements feel genuinely threatening and alien
- tem Create sense of isolation and hopelessness that makes supernatural solutions tempting
- tem Balance horror with folk wisdom and community resilience

10.2 Folk Horror Elements

Use local customs and superstitions authentically:

- tem Specific folk practices should have mechanical effects
- tem Local knowledge should be valuable and hard to find elsewhere
- tem Supernatural threats should be tied to regional folklore
- tem Community responses should reflect genuine cultural practices

10.3 Moral Ambiguity

Present difficult choices without clear right answers:

- tem Each resolution path should have significant costs and benefits
- tem NPCs should have complex motivations rather than simple good/evil
- tem Supernatural forces should be neither entirely benevolent nor malevolent
- tem Player choices should have lasting consequences that affect character development

10.4 Escalating Tension

Gradually increase supernatural threat level:

- tem Session 1: Minor disturbances and growing unease
- tem Session 2: Clear supernatural manifestations and local knowledge
- tem Session 3: Direct confrontation with entity and community crisis
- tem Session 4: Climactic encounter with legendary figure and final choice

10.5 Player Agency

Provide multiple paths to resolution:

- tem Investigation approach: Master curse mechanics and find proper solution
- tem Social approach: Negotiate with factions and supernatural entities
- tem Direct action approach: Confront threats through force or ritual
- tem Moral approach: Make difficult choices that affect curse's ultimate fate

10.6 Story Beats

Use curse's influence to generate complications:

- tem 1 SB: Minor supernatural manifestation, small equipment failure
- tem 2 SB: NPC becomes temporarily possessed, important item goes missing
- tem 3 SB: Major curse escalation, community member suffers serious harm
- tem 4+ SB: Entity direct intervention, climactic supernatural event

10.7 SessionSpecific Guidance

Session 1 Focus: Establish supernatural threat and desperate situation. Players should feel immediate need to help while sensing something deeper is wrong.

Session 2 Focus: Deepen supernatural elements and introduce local knowledge. Players learn curse has ancient, complex origins requiring specialized solutions.

Session 3 Focus: Escalate to communitywide crisis and direct supernatural confrontation. Players must make difficult choices under pressure.

Session 4 Focus: Climactic resolution with moral complexity. All previous elements converge in final choices with lasting consequences.

10.8 Alternative Endings

If players attempt unconventional solutions:

tem **Community Solution:** Rally local population to perform massive protective ritual

tem **Entity Alliance:** Negotiate with Hungering Dark to become its agent tem **Folk Hero**

Path: Become legendary figures who regularly deal with supernatural threats tem **Cursed**

Path: Become cursed themselves but gain supernatural powers

10.9 Scaling for Different Tiers

Tier II (Seasoned): Standard supernatural threats, manageable curse effects, local community scope.

Tier III (Veteran): More powerful entities, curse spreading to multiple communities, regional political implications.

Tier IV (Paragon): Ancient conspiracy involving multiple cursed objects, entity gains patron backing, threat to entire region.